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Rs 1,600 per quintal. It is now Rs 2,800 per quintal. For a farmer who produces 200 quintals of soyabean, it means additional income of almost Rs 2.50 lakh. No wonder then from hatchbacks to suvs, it's all available in local showrooms. Says Ramaraj Verma, a local farmer: "People now have pucca houses, electronic goods, swanky cars, mobiles and refrigerators."

Technology Rules Much of the new prosperity is to do with connectivity and new channels of communication. Rural road projects have made it easier and faster for farmers to get their produce to markets while communication tools have given them access to weather forecasts and critical inputs. ITC's e-chaupal reaches 3.5 million farmers giving them instant access to data on new varieties of crops, pricing and markets. Laptop in hand, K. P. Reddy of Bellandur, a tiny village near Bangalore, is a farmer-turned-social entrepreneur who fought to ensure that the village adopted computers to access land certificates for its farmers. That has reduced land disputes and given farmers a realistic idea of the value of their holdings.

In West Bengal, Bardhaman has become the only district in the country to become fully Internet-connected with panchayats organising video conferences across the district.

The network helps daily administrative work and is part of the existing State Wide Area Network (SWAN), a Union Government initiative under the National e-governance plan. Municipalities like Memary have also been pro-active. It opened a computer school to train young men and women. Says student Asit Pramanick: "Internet connectivity has made the world a much smaller place."

To really see how much rural India has changed, visit Anksapur in Nizamabad district of Andhra Pradesh. The palatial buildings and wide roads in a rural setting is a surreal sight. It has more migrant farm workers than residents. They can earn more in Anksapur where farmers grow multiple cash crops and have established efficient water management systems. Every farmer has an average of four labourers working for them to cope with increased yields. Every one of the 600-odd farmers has a motorcycle and every sixth family a car. Such is the prosperity that Anksapur farmers who cultivate all 2,000 acres of arable land in the village have also bought 1,500 acres in neighbouring villages. "It is a saga of planning and implementation of water resource development by a generation of farmers," says P. Gangaram, an agriculture expert. Modern water management techniques like drip irrigation give farmers enough water to irrigate three crops

 **OM PRAKASH**
FARMER, HARYANA

Om Prakash from Ghata village in Gurgaon lives in a palatial house in Ansal's upscale Sushant Lok. His village has many such families who made a killing by selling agricultural land to one of the many private builders during Gurgaon's real estate boom. He still retains his rustic habits but his two sons are totally urbanised, dressed in jeans, T-shirts and sneakers. They flaunt expensive mobiles and drive fancy cars.

WITH cities expanding AND REAL ESTATE COMPANIES ENTERING RURAL MARKETS, FARMERS HAVE sold their land AND NOW LIVE LIVES THEY HAD ONLY SEEN IN THE MOVIES.

